# Las Hermanas from Parallel Lives

## By Mo Gaffney and Kathy Najimy

***NOTE: The original script of Parallel Lives was written for two women to play multiple roles. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.***

## INTRODUCTION

***ACTRESS 1:*** *Let us take you back in time to the early nineties*

***ACTRESS 2:*** *When the feminist comedy* Parallel Lives *— written and performed by openly bisexual actors and writers* ***Kathy Najimy*** *and* ***Mo Gaffney*** *— made its debut,*

***ACTRESS 1:*** *It was the George Bush era . . . . and the political climate was still rather grim for LGBT people.*

***ACTRESS 2:*** *It was well before there were multiple celebrities "coming out" - Melissa Etheridge . . . Ellen DeGeneres*

***ACTRESS 1:*** *And lesbian characters and story lines were, for the most part, a rarity on network television and in feature films.*

***ACTRESS 2:*** *Women were recognizing and naming themselves as feminists and the world was still in shock.*

***ACTRESS 1:*** *In Las Hermanas -- two senior citizens, Sylvia and Madeline, go on a field trip to an all-natural restaurant with their women's studies class and experience some unintentionally hilarious lesbian-feminist performance art ("Sister Woman Sister!").*

***TOGETHER:*** *Las Hermanas from Parallel Lives by Mo Gaffney and Kathy Najimy*

*Lights come up on two sixty-something New Yorkers, Madeline and Sylvia*

**MADELINE:** Is this the place Syvvie?

**SYLVIA:** I guess so, darling. I don't usually frequent health food places.

**MADELINE:** Neither do I, don't be smart.

**SYLVIA:** *(Indicating sign.)* Oh, here we go: "Las Hermanas."

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**MADELINE:** Oh, that means *'the* sisters' in Hispanic. Oh look Syvvie, all the plants and the wicker.

**SYLVIA:** Oh Mad, look at this floral water color! It's so vibrant.

**MADELINE:** I love art, oh it's beautiful. Well, do you see anyone here? Hostess? Waitress? Maitre d'?

**SYLVIA:** Right here. Hello darling.

**MADELINE:** Oh, hello honey, we're here with the Women's Studies field trip department. Is there a special section we should sit in? We're here to see Holly and Molly sing Sister Woman Sister. We want to sit with our class . . .

**SYLVIA:** Maybe we should introduce ourselves. I don't mean to interrupt.

**MADELINE:** I didn't introduce, I'm sorry. You're right, I'm wrong. My name is Madeline Samuels, and this is my best friend in the entire universe, forty three and a half years . . .

**SYLVIA:** My name is Sylvia Dunleavy, but please call me Syvvie.

**MADELINE:** We're with the Women's Studies Department junior college extension program. Oh we love it, two years we've been there. Tell her the story, darling, she doesn't know us.

**SYLVIA:** Well, a couple of years ago Mad and I decided to go back to school.

**MADELINE:** Single again, why not. . . ?

**SYLVIA:** We wanted to take a real estate course but it was all filled up.

**MADELINE:** So what we did was we went down to the registrar's office and we looked through the book, the hibiscus, whatever . . . to see what they had to offer . . .

**SYLVIA:** We didn't know.

**MADELINE:** We didn't care. And we see, big as day, Women's Studies, and we think, 'hoho!'

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**SYLVIA:** Hoho!

**MADELINE:** We've got the prerequisite for *this* course. At the time we had no idea. Women's Studies we thought it would be a little macramé.

**SYLVIA:** Maybe some child rearing.

**MADELINE:** Whip stitching.

**BOTH:** No very serious courses.

**SYLVIA:** Our first class was a 'Women in Terrorism' course. It was scary, but I got an A. *(Karate stance.)* Watch yourself. Oh I wouldn't hurt you, I'm just kidding.

**MADELINE:** I wasn't good, my favorite was second semester, 'Women and Their Body Temperatures.' I cried in that class. Honey, you learn things you don't want to know.

**SYLVIA:** Things you wish you could forget.

**MADELINE:** You can't forget mucus, it just sticks to you.

**SYLVIA:** Oh, remember our favorite class? "Women in Human Sexuality."

**MADELINE:** Human sexuality, choices, choices, choices . . . It's a whole new world with the choices nowadays. What with your . . . you know with your . . . your bi-sexist and your lesbanese.

**SYLVIA:** Don't forget the celebastics who have no sex whatsoever.

**MADELINE:** Who cares, everybody marches to their own individual drum cycle.

**SYLVIA:** I'm okay and you're delightful.

**MADELINE:** Do you know what I always say? I say please do not walk in front of me or at the side of me, walk behind me as my equal. That's all she said. . . You'll find the reservation under Carol Perkins.

**SYLVIA:** She's our professor and such a genius. She is so smart at least six PhDs maybe more. We love her.

**MADELINE:** Beautiful, wears the folk skirts, long grey braid, very tan, Indian

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jewelry . . . Oh? follow her? She must be in a hurry. *(They walk over to sit on bench.)* These tree stumps must be the seats. Watch out for splinters in your fanny.

**SYLVIA:** *(Sitting.)* I feel like I'm a 7 dwarf, what with the tree stumps. Oh, look . . . *(Picks up flyer.)* "Holly and Molly in 'Sister Woman Sister.'" That's what we're here to see.

**MADELINE:** Performance art field trip, next week we see the Katie and Mo show or something . . . It's a performance art class.

**SYLVIA:** Doesn't matter what you do, you get a grade.

**MADELINE:** Some of the projects those girls do are wild.

**SYLVIA:** Women. I don't mean to contradict you.

**MADELINE:** Oh, no, you are right. I'm glad you told me. I'm wrong.

**SYLVIA:** You're not wrong darling, you got it right on the test so you know it up here. *(Points to her head.)*

**MADELINE:** I stand corrected. May I start over? Do overs. Do overs. Some of the projects the 'women' do are wild.

**SYLVIA:** Tell her about the first project.

**MADELINE:** Her name was Teria.

**SYLVIA:** I think it means the wind. So Teria blew in. Just kidding. She comes in wearing nothing but a bikini.

**MADELINE:** French cut, yellow terry cloth thong. Thongs. You used to wear it on your feet. Now you wear it on your butt!

**SYLVIA:** Anywho, she has with her a watermelon.

**MADELINE:** Ripe!

**SYLVIA:** And I think, delicious! But no, she slices it in half and rubs it all over her body, tip to toe, doesn't miss a spot with the watermelon.

**MADELINE:** Then, for the *piece de resistance,* she takes a box of live flies and

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mosquitoes. True story, and unleashes them on herself. Yes, she did.

**SYLVIA:** She called it "Summer." It went right over my head. She meant well, she really did.

**MADELINE:** No, I didn't have a clue. Made me hungry for cantaloupe. The teacher was on her knees weeping. I didn't get it, she got an A+ right off the top.

**SYLVIA:** Well, what do we know.

**MADELINE:** Not a thing. Not about art anyway. Well here's the menu decoupaged on that tree trunk up there.

**SYLVIA:** So crafty.

**MADELINE:** I'll tell you what, my glasses are better, I'll order for you. What will you have?

**SYLVIA:** I think I'll have a burger, medium well, with ...

**BOTH:** Onions.

**MADELINE:** Miss Onionhead. *(Squinting and searching hanging menu.]* All right, okay, all right, okay, all right. No, Syvvie, no burgers, no franks.

**SYLVIA:** No burgers?

**MADELINE:** Not here.

**SYLVIA:** Should we be scared?

**MADELINE:** No, tell you what, We're gonna try the special of the day no matter what it is.

**SYLVIA:** Okay, we'll be adventurous. We ain't dead yet.

**MADELINE:** *(They crack up.)* Oh, look honey, over by the tree trunk, folk skirt. Carol!

**SYLVIA:** Professor Perkins!!

**MADELINE:** *(To Carol.)* Mad and Syvvie. Second period, right on time. Come over

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and sit with us.

**SYLVIA:** Oh, she wouldn't sit with us. She'll probably sit with Teria.

**MADELINE:** No darling, look, she's coming over. The lights are going down, the big sister show is going to start. Shhhhhh . . .

*(Actress assume the roles of Holly and Molly who are wearing women's symbol T-shirts)*

**HOLLY:** Welcome to Las Hermanas. My name is Holly and my partner Molly and I would like to thank the owners of Las Hermanas, Nirvana and Sunshine, for providing us with a chemical-free, meat-free male-free environment.

**MOLLY:** An environment about women, through women, beyond women, because of women, over women, of women, above women, by women and for women only. We'd like to start with an original tune.

**BOTH:** *(singing)* Sister Woman Sister
Mother, daughter me
Sister, you run naked
Wild and so free
You know how to run and jump and laugh and climb a tree
Sister Woman Sister
You are me

**MOLLY:** And now, in a tribute to Holly Near, Meg Christian, Theresa Troll and Helen Reddy, we'd like to share with you . . .

**BOTH:** SISTER WOMAN SISTER

**HOLLY:** Oh sister woman sister, mother goddess, oh goddess, bring me into your fold, your mother loving arms . . . your sister woman motherloving arms.

**MOLLY:** WOMYN W-O-M-Y-N, pronounced wmyn. Solstice wmyn witch wmyn.

**HOLLY:** Birth Cycle.

**MOLLY:** I am born from you and am of you . . of you I am . . .

**HOLLY:** We give birth. We are birth, we are fetal, we are after birth. My

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placenta is yours and yours is mine.

**MOLLY:** So sister. Can I call you sister, or woman of my life, or just me? Are you me? Are we we?

**HOLLY:** Oh, live in the great uterus of woman. Live in the walls. Cut the umbilical cord.

**BOTH:** No! Don't!

**HOLLY:** It is there.

**BOTH:** Cord cut cut cord no don't!

**HOLLY:** It is there.

**BOTH:** Woman woman woman woman womn womn wom wom wom WOMB!

**MOLLY:** Womb, womb, we are two evolving around into oneness. Spinning, spinning, spinning . . . spinning.

**HOLLY:** Oh, labia. Oh golden labia of goddess love. So let your champagne flow.

**MOLLY:** Like blook, like spit, like rain, like wet, wet woman, woman, wet. They both start with a W. We are the lioness, we are the tigress, we are THE TEAMSTERS.

**HOLLY:** Sisters, sisters Betty and Wilma . . .

**MOLLY:** No Fred, no Barney.

**BOTH (alternating):** I / have / my / own / I / den / tit / y / I / have / my / own I/ den / tit / y.

**MOLLY:** I have my own identity, I have my own identity.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Mo Gaffney and Kathy Najimi***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2003 National Qualifier***
***2007 National Qualifier***
***2014 National Qualifier***
***2015 National Qualifier***
***2016 National Qualifier***